

The 2026 Infrastructure, Construction, and Engineering Opportunity Playbook

A field guide to capital plans, federal funding flows, local projects, prime contractors, subcontract routes, and pre-bid intelligence.

6 lanes Capital, grant, project, prime, subcontract, and planning routes	Flow down Funding must be traced to implementers	30 days A geography-led pursuit plan
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Built for founders and revenue teams that need credible targets, clear revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions - not a generic list of grants or contracts.

Opportunity Scanner by Opportunity Systems

Research current as of July 27, 2026. Always recheck time-sensitive official sources before acting.

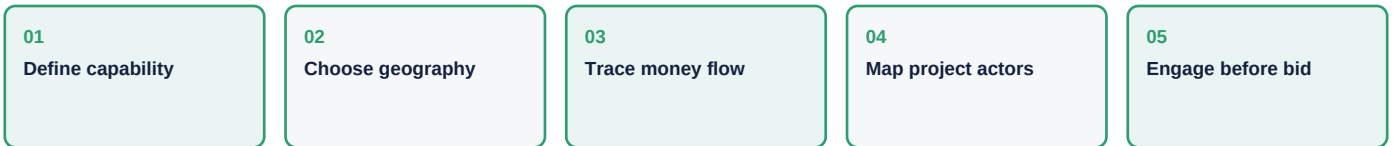
The opportunity landscape

Use these lanes to separate records that imply different buyers, partners, timing, and next actions.

6 evidence lanes to investigate



From signal to an owned revenue action



These diagrams are operating maps, not a promise that every lane is open. The report explains the evidence, constraints, and qualification checks behind each route.

Updated: July 27, 2026

Audience: Contractors, specialty trades, engineering and design firms, equipment and material suppliers, construction-technology providers, environmental consultants, and infrastructure service companies

Purpose: A practical guide to tracing public infrastructure money into real projects, buyers, prime contracts, and subcontracting actions

Executive brief

The Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act (IIJA), commonly called the Bipartisan Infrastructure Law (BIL), became Public Law 117-58 on November 15, 2021. Its opportunity is still active in 2026, but the actionable market is no longer captured by a headline appropriation alone. Money moves through federal agencies, formula apportionments, competitive grants, loans and capitalization grants, then through states, tribes, territories, local governments, utilities, authorities, universities, nonprofits, and private awardees. Those recipients plan projects, complete environmental and grant requirements, assemble match, advertise procurements, select primes, and issue subcontracts and purchase orders.

That chain creates several markets: direct grants, agency bids, funded-buyer sales, prime partnerships, and supplier work. The correct move depends on where the money and project are.

In April 2025, the [Government Accountability Office \(GAO\)](#) reported that 15 agencies identified approximately \$711.8 billion in IIJA appropriations available as grants to tribes, states, localities, and territories across more than 100 programs. Of that, \$580.6 billion became available for obligation in FY2022-FY2025 and \$131.2 billion was expected in FY2026. As of December 31, 2024, agencies had obligated \$275.1 billion and outlayed \$119.4 billion of the earlier available amount. These are GAO-defined grant figures, not current unspent cash or a contractor-addressable market.

The timing gap is both opportunity and warning. An appropriation gives budget authority; an apportionment or allocation assigns funds; an obligation creates a legal commitment; an outlay is a payment. A selection may precede an agreement, and an award may precede local bidding by months or years.

For 2026, the practical method is:

1. Start with a funded program, award, plan, or named project, not a broad infrastructure theme.
2. Trace the responsible federal agency and the actual recipient.
3. Determine project phase: planning, design, environmental review, right-of-way, procurement, construction, or operations.
4. Find the recipient's procurement route and likely prime contractors.
5. Qualify location, licenses, bonding, labor, domestic-content, safety, schedule, and capacity.
6. Assign the right revenue motion and a dated next action.

Opportunity Scanner joins official records into an Opportunity Signal: funding, current controller, project, fit, contact path, and next action. It should not label every award as an open bid.

State of the market: funding is moving downstream

1. FY2026 is a final authorization year for many core BIL transportation amounts, not the end of project work

Programs have different availability and obligation deadlines. GAO reported that IIJA authorized and appropriated more than \$551 billion to DOT for about 100 grant programs. Much surface-transportation funding covers FY2022-FY2026, but funded projects can continue later.

As of April 2025, [GAO reported](#) that DOT had obligated 59% of its available IIJA grant funding and outlayed more than half of that. Awardees cited inflation, budget and schedule definition, NEPA reviews, and Build America, Buy America requirements as common challenges. In March 2026, GAO still listed its funding-status and portfolio-risk recommendations as open. Use dated records; an old headline minus obligations is not a pipeline.

2. Formula funding usually makes the state or local system the real market

Federal-aid highway money is apportioned to states, which program projects through state and metropolitan processes. FHWA's [FY2022-FY2026 estimates](#) show state amounts for core highway and formula programs. They show scale, not project bids.

For project discovery, use STIPs, metropolitan TIPs, state DOT lettings, local capital plans, board agendas, and procurement portals. [FTA](#) says a TIP includes regionally significant projects receiving FHWA or FTA funds or requiring approval. A TIP line may lack final design, permits, full funding, or a bid date, but it identifies the sponsor early.

3. Water funding flows through state revolving funds

EPA capitalizes Clean Water and Drinking Water State Revolving Funds; states operate financing programs and project lists. Vendors should normally track the state program and local utility, not pitch EPA as the project buyer.

EPA issued [FY2026 SRF allotments](#) in April 2026; its memorandum keeps a 20% state match for FY2026 IJA General Supplemental capitalization grants. EPA's May 2026 lead-service-line allotments give eligible jurisdictions until September 30, 2027 to apply for and receive those funds. Allotment is not a construction notice; follow the state's project list and the utility's schedule.

4. Broadband is transitioning from state selection into implementation

The \$42.45 billion BEAD program runs through states and territories. In March 2026, [BroadbandUSA reported](#) 53 approved final proposals, 50 with NIST approval making funds available, and 38 signed award agreements. This is a March snapshot, not July status.

Useful records are the [state BEAD plans, portals, and milestones](#), subgrantee selections, agreements, permits, and provider build plans. Vendors normally sell to the selected subgrantee or network prime unless state procurement says otherwise.

5. Energy and grid opportunities mix public and private recipients

DOE can fund states, tribes, utilities, authorities, manufacturers, and consortia. Its [GRIP project page](#) lists parties, cost shares, status, round, and location, but says content reflects December 2024 information. "Selected" and "awarded" are not interchangeable, and neither proves an open subcontract.

DOE's February 2026 [\\$1.9 billion SPARK opportunity](#) had concept papers due April 2, applications due May 20, and selections anticipated in August. As of July 11, monitor selections and recipient supply chains; applications are closed.

6. Direct federal construction remains a separate lane

Some work is procured directly, including USACE civil works. USACE publishes work plans and district forecasts; SAM.gov remains the governmentwide contract-opportunity entry point. [USACE guidance](#) recommends tracking planned and solicited work and using district small-business offices. A work-plan line is not a solicitation.

Eight opportunity lanes

Lane	Buyer or counterparty	Typical source signal	Revenue motion
Direct federal construction	USACE, GSA, federal land or facility agency	Work plan, forecast, SAM notice	Direct prime or Sell to Award Recipient
State formula project	State DOT or state agency	Apportionment, STIP, letting schedule	Sell to Agency or prime
Local/MPO transportation project	City, county, transit authority, port, airport	TIP, capital plan, board action, local RFP	Sell to Funded Buyer
Water and wastewater project	State SRF recipient, utility, municipality	Intended-use plan, project priority list, bond/board action	Sell to Funded Buyer

Lane	Buyer or counterparty	Typical source signal	Revenue motion
Broadband deployment	State/territory subgrantee or selected provider	Approved final proposal, subgrant, provider announcement	Sell to Award Recipient
Grid and energy project	Utility, state, tribe, authority, consortium	DOE selection/award, commission filing, recipient procurement	Sell to Award Recipient or Partner with Recipient
Materials and equipment	Prime, recipient, distributor	Bid tab, specifications, procurement package	Channel / Distributor Motion
Planning, permitting, compliance, and operations	Sponsor, engineer, construction manager, prime	Planning study, grant agreement, environmental record	Sell to Funded Buyer or Award Recipient

Direct Apply is appropriate only where the company is an eligible applicant and wants to carry the grant's administrative, match, reporting, and performance obligations. Most private construction vendors will more often sell to the agency, funded recipient, or prime.

How to trace funding into a project

Step 1: Name the federal program and money type

Record the Assistance Listing or program name, federal agency and subagency, statutory source, fiscal year, formula versus discretionary structure, award instrument, and period of availability. Label amounts accurately: authorized, appropriated, apportioned, allocated, selected, obligated, outlayed, award ceiling, or project total. Include nonfederal match separately.

If the source says "up to" or "selected for negotiation," preserve that language. Do not convert it to an award.

Step 2: Identify who controls the next decision

The federal agency may have already transferred the practical buying decision. Name the prime recipient, subrecipient if reported, project sponsor, implementing department, procurement office, and governing board. For formula transportation, this may be the state DOT or local sponsor. For SRF, it is often a state financing authority followed by a utility. For BEAD, it is the state broadband office followed by the selected subgrantee. For a DOE award, it may be a utility or consortium lead.

Step 3: Locate the project record

Search for a project title, location, route, facility, utility system, award identifier, and recipient. Useful official records include STIPs/TIPs, intended-use plans, environmental review pages, grant agreements, capital plans, council or authority agendas, engineering solicitations, plan-holder lists, pre-bid meetings, bid tabs, award recommendations, and notices to proceed.

A project title can change between the federal award and local procurement. Preserve aliases and identifiers in Opportunity Scanner.

Step 4: Determine phase and procurement window

Use these phases:

- **Programmed:** appears in a plan or funding list; scope and timing may move.
- **Selected:** announced for funding but award conditions may remain.
- **Awarded/obligated:** legal commitment exists; recipient procurement may still be pending.
- **Planning/environmental:** consultants and technical services may be actionable before construction.
- **Design/right-of-way/permitting:** specifications and bid packaging are forming.
- **Advertised:** procurement is open; amendments and pre-bid requirements control.

- **Awarded to prime:** subcontract, supplier, staffing, and execution routes may remain.
- **Construction/operations:** change orders, later phases, maintenance, inspection, and replacement may remain, subject to procurement rules.

Step 5: Map the contract chain

Draw the chain: federal agency -> recipient -> sponsor -> design/construction manager -> prime -> subcontractor/supplier. USAspending reports federal prime and subaward data; state and local records may sit in recipient systems, business directories, or prime notices.

Step 6: Build a contact path

Use role-based routes: notice contact, small-business office, program manager, sponsor procurement office, engineer, plan room, prime estimator, pre-bid conference, or public meeting. Respect post-advertisement communication rules. The correct path may be registration, a formal question, or a subcontractor portal.

Qualification framework

Score 0, 1, or 2 for each factor:

Factor	0	1	2
Scope fit	General adjacency	Partial package fit	Exact trade/product/service fit
Funding evidence	Headline only	Program/project listed	Award/plan and amount type verified
Phase/timing	Too late or unknown	Future with milestone	Actionable pre-bid, bid, or prime-buy window
Buyer/chain clarity	Unknown	Recipient known	Sponsor, procurement route, and prime known
Geography/capacity	Outside reach	Capacity requires partner	Can staff, mobilize, and deliver
Compliance readiness	Major unknowns	Gaps with owner	Licenses, safety, labor, domestic content understood
Financial readiness	Cannot support	Bonding/cash flow to confirm	Bonding, insurance, cash flow and terms workable
Competitive position	No proof/access	Transferable proof	Relevant proof, relationship, certification, or package advantage
Next action	Generic outreach	Contact hypothesis	Named owner, channel, deliverable, and date

14-18: High Actionability. Begin capture, bid, or prime outreach.

9-13: Medium Actionability. Resolve phase, route, or compliance gaps first.

0-8: Low Actionability. Monitor or archive.

Apply hard gates separately: bidder eligibility, license, bonding, mandatory pre-bid attendance, geographic restriction, certification, security or badging, approved-equals rule, Buy America/Build America Buy America (BABA), Davis-Bacon, disadvantaged-business requirements, insurance, schedule, and bid deadline. Requirements vary by program and contract; do not infer them from the BIL label alone.

Source-to-action table

Official source	What it proves	What it does not prove	Action
Public Law 117-58	Statutory authority and program provisions	Current project or available balance	Identify program, section, agency, and period
GAO IIJA grant status	Dated cross-agency appropriation, obligation, and outlay analysis	July 2026 live balance	Use as market context; verify current program records
USAspending	Reported federal awards, recipients, obligations, subawards	Local bid status or complete subcontract chain	Capture award ID; follow recipient and project
Grants.gov	Open/forecast federal assistance notice and eligibility	Construction procurement under an existing award	Apply only if eligible; otherwise track resulting recipients
State STIP/MPO TIP	Programmed transportation project, sponsor, years	Final bid date or full funding	Follow sponsor, design phase, and letting calendar
State SRF intended-use/project list	Candidate or planned water financing	Notice to proceed or vendor selection	Follow utility board, engineer, and procurement portal
NTIA BEAD state resources	State process, approvals, portals, sometimes subgrantees	An open subcontract	Identify selected provider and implementation geography
DOE GRIP projects	Named selectee/recipient, status, cost share, location	Current procurement or unchanged status	Verify recipient release; map partners and supply chain
USACE planned opportunities	District forecast/work-plan context	Active governmentwide solicitation	Track district and SAM.gov notice
Recipient procurement portal	Controlling local advertisement and instructions	Federal program-wide demand	Register, attend required meetings, follow amendments
Prime bid invitation/plan room	Package, plans, due date, estimator contact	Public award certainty	Qualify scope; submit compliant quote and exclusions

Compliance factors that change the pursuit

The Build America, Buy America Act establishes domestic-preference requirements for iron, steel, manufactured products, and construction materials used in covered infrastructure projects under federal financial assistance. The [Made in America Office](#) publishes agency waiver information and explains that proposed waivers generally receive a 15-day public review. Applicability, product standards, and waivers are award-specific. Suppliers should document origin, manufacturing process, component data where required, and any approved waiver rather than offer a generic "Made in USA" statement.

The [Department of Labor's BIL fact sheet](#) says a vast majority of BIL-authorized construction funding requires Davis-Bacon prevailing wages through direct coverage or a Related Act. Covered recipients must insert applicable clauses and wage determinations; contractors and subcontractors have pay and recordkeeping duties. Broadband programs under Division F are treated differently in that fact sheet, illustrating why the contract and funding statute must be checked. As of July 2026, DOL also notes litigation affecting portions of its 2023 Davis-Bacon rule on its [current construction guidance page](#); obtain current counsel or agency guidance for disputed provisions.

Other recurring gates include NEPA and permitting, disadvantaged business enterprise or local participation goals, certified payroll, Buy America regimes specific to transportation, OSHA and owner safety rules, performance and payment bonds, cyber requirements for connected assets, and grant flow-down clauses. Price compliance and reporting work into the job.

A 30-day operating plan

Days 1-5: Define capacity and territory

Document trades and NAICS codes, licenses, bonding range, insurance, crew and equipment capacity, mobilization radius, union/nonunion constraints, certifications, safety metrics, past projects, material origins, and ideal package size. Separate prime-ready work from subcontract-ready work. Choose no more than three infrastructure lanes and five target geographies.

Days 6-10: Build a 50-record funding-to-project set

Use Opportunity Scanner to collect federal program records, dated awards, recipients, project plans, and procurement sources. At least half the records should be downstream of the federal agency: STIP/TIP projects, SRF lists, recipient board actions, BEAD subgrantees, utility filings, local advertisements, USACE district forecasts, or prime notices. Store official URL, date, amount type, project phase, location, recipient, and identifier.

Days 11-15: Trace and score

Deduplicate projects appearing across several sources. For the top 20, draw the contract chain and find the recipient procurement portal. Score each and apply hard gates. Select no more than 12 pursuits: a mix of pre-bid positioning, advertised procurements, prime/subcontract routes, and monitored projects. Closed grants can remain only when they reveal a funded recipient with future procurement.

Days 16-21: Establish source-native contact

Register in required vendor and plan-room systems. Attend available pre-bid or industry events. Ask formal questions through the stated channel. For pre-procurement projects, give the sponsor or engineer a short capability statement tied to location, package, schedule, and proof. For awarded projects, approach the prime's estimator or supplier team with a specific scope and capacity. Log every contact and follow-up date.

Days 22-26: Prepare bid readiness

Confirm bonding, insurance, labor rates, wage determination, material origin, lead times, approved-equal process, permits, safety submittals, quality plan, schedule, cash-flow exposure, retainage, payment terms, and flow-downs. Line up partners for gaps. Review addenda and acknowledge them. Set a no-bid threshold for margin, risk, geography, and capacity.

Days 27-30: Hold a pipeline review

Advance each record to pursue, partner, monitor, or stop. Every active pursuit should show: controlling source, current phase, buyer/prime, amount type, fit, compliance gates, decision date, owner, and next action. Track leading indicators such as plan-room access, estimator conversations, approved vendor status, prequalification, and invitation to quote, not just bids submitted.

Caveats and responsible use

- This report is not legal, labor, environmental, grant, engineering, or bonding advice. The award and contract control.
- IJJA/BIL, IRA, annual appropriations, state funds, bonds, and ratepayer funds may coexist in one project. Do not attribute the full project value to BIL without evidence.
- "Selected," "awarded," "obligated," and "outlayed" are different statuses. Preserve the source's term.
- Formula estimates and grant allocations are not bid values. Project totals may include match, financing, design, right-of-way, contingency, and nonconstruction costs.
- A federal award to a state or utility does not make every downstream purchase a federal procurement; recipient rules and federal flow-downs both matter.
- Program policy, waiver status, grant agreements, schedules, and administration priorities can change. Re-verify before outreach or bid.
- Use role-based public contacts and permitted procurement channels. Do not seek nonpublic bid information.

Source ledger

Source	Period or publication date	Use in this report	Caveat
Public Law 117-58	Enacted November 15, 2021	Statutory basis and program periods	Later law and agency actions may modify implementation
GAO-25-107243	Data through December 31, 2024; published April 29, 2025	Cross-agency grant flow and definitions	Dated snapshot; GAO-defined scope
GAO-25-107166	Funding through April 2025; status updated March 2026	DOT obligations, outlays, awardee risks	Not a live project ledger
FHWA FY2022-FY2026 formula estimates	FY2022-FY2026	State formula-funding context	Estimates, not project bids
FTA TIP guidance	Checked July 11, 2026	Role of metropolitan project programming	TIP inclusion is not advertisement
EPA FY2026 SRF allotments	Issued April 14, 2026	Water funding flow and FY2026 allotments	State/local lists control project selection
EPA FY2026 lead-service-line allotment memorandum	Issued May 20, 2026	FY2026 LSLR timing	Allotment is not local procurement
BroadbandUSA March 2026 newsletter	March 2026	Dated BEAD implementation snapshot	Counts must be refreshed
BEAD plans and milestones	Live resource; checked July 11, 2026	State portals, approvals, subgrantee process	State records may update first
DOE GRIP projects	Page says content through December 2024	Recipient, status and cost-share fields	Verify current recipient status
DOE SPARK announcement	Published March 12, 2026	Closed 2026 funding cycle and anticipated selections	Deadlines passed; selection was anticipated, not guaranteed
USACE upcoming opportunities	Checked July 11, 2026	Direct federal work-plan and forecast route	SAM.gov notice controls competition
Made in America financial-assistance resources	Checked July 11, 2026	BABA overview and waiver route	Agency and award details control
DOL Fact Sheet 66A	Checked July 11, 2026	Davis-Bacon treatment of BIL projects	General guidance; current law and contract control
USAspending data documentation	Live documentation; checked July 11, 2026	Prime and subaward tracing	Reporting completeness and lag vary

Put this guide to work

Opportunity Scanner reads your company website, finds source-backed public-sector signals, and translates them into target organizations, revenue motions, contact paths, and next actions.

Run a free company scan at opportunityscanner.ai

Recheck official sources before any outreach, application, registration, or bid decision.